certainly provide for easier integration into the vaccine passport mechanism around the world. As predicted, by October 2021, several countries had opened up travel and while it took activation of several diplomatic channels by the Indian government to facilitate recognition of the CoWIN certificate, they were successful in ensuring that our certificates stood ground around the world.

At the summit, the prime minister also pressed for text-based negotiations for a temporary patent waiver for COVID-19 vaccines—an idea that resonated strongly with the participating leaders and the UN General Secretary, António Guterres. A TRIPS (Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights) waiver would highly benefit middle- and low-income nations to access vaccines. As early as October, India and South Africa had approached the World Trade Organization (WTO) to seek temporary waiver on parts of the agreement on TRIPS.[18] While initially the President Joe Biden-led US government was opposed to the idea, months later it finally came around in the interest of speeding up vaccination drives equitably worldwide.

Placing our bets where our word was, and in an effort to ensure that all countries had equal access to vaccines, we began our vaccine diplomacy programme ‘Vaccine Maitri’. Ever since India had begun to plan its vaccination process, the prime minister had been of the firm opinion that unless everyone was safe, no one was. This meant that unless the whole world had equitable access to vaccines, the pandemic would not go away. Having led the country from dependant to supplier status for medical essential equipment such as N95 masks, PPE kits and ventilators as well as several medicines crucial in the fight against COVID-19, the prime minister was certain that India would live up to being ‘the pharmacy of the world’ even when it came to vaccine supplies. Unlike other western countries which engaged in vaccine nationalism displaying their power, India, true to its nurturing soft-power character, engaged with the rest of the world as a provider—fulfilling other’s needs, alongside looking after its own.

In addition, our vaccine manufacturers had pre-decided agreements with select nations to provide a certain amount of doses in exchange for the raw materials that they would provide. It was important to adhere to these as well. By the third quarter of 2020, Adar Poonawalla, CEO of SII, had raised over ₹10,000 crore from COVAX and advances for orders from several other nations in exchange for providing timely, requisite doses of